

Doncaster High Street

Conservation Area Appraisal and Management Proposals

Doncaster Council
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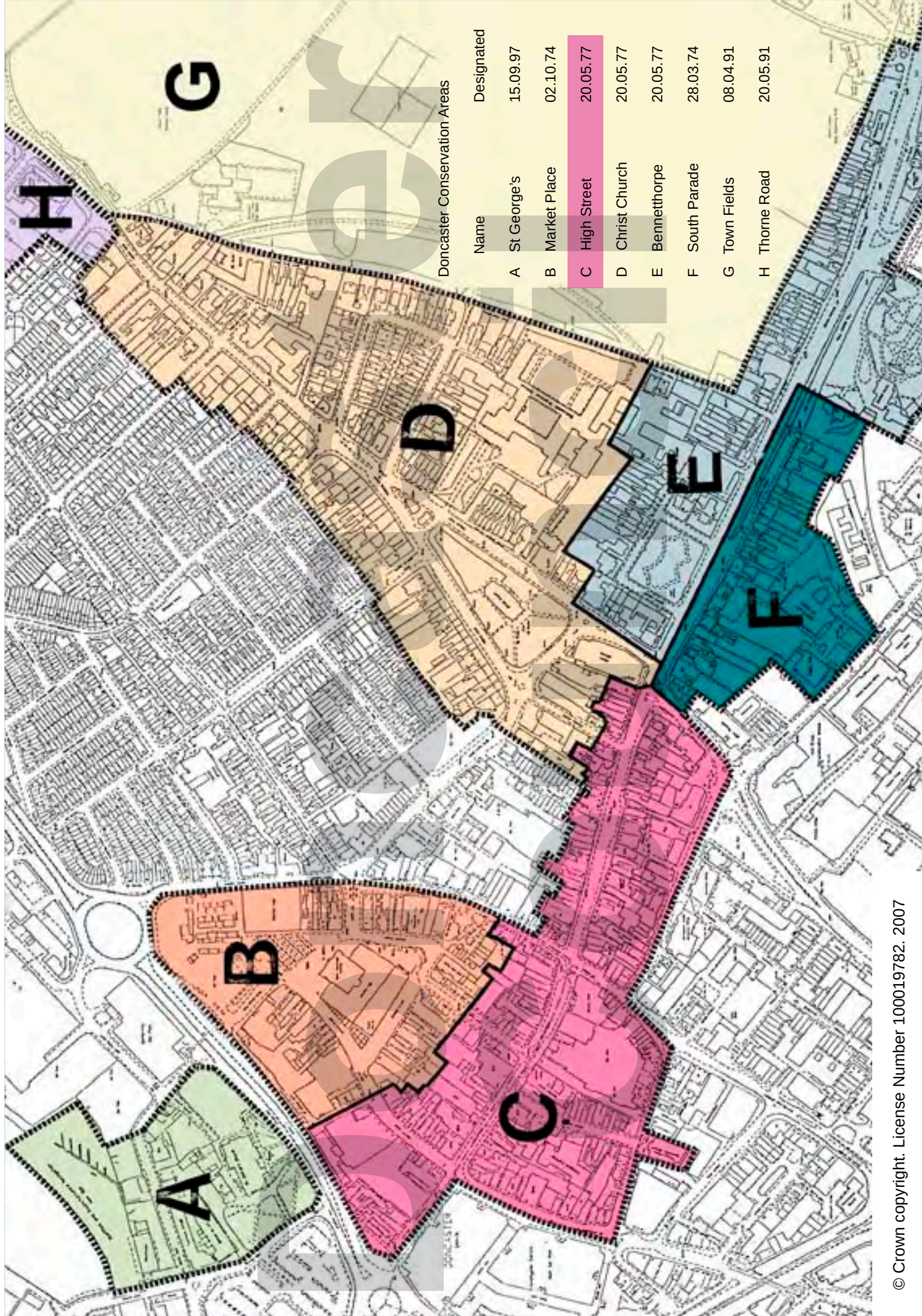
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Introduction

1.1 Background

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The Origin and Purpose of the Appraisal

Doncaster Council commissioned John Thompson and Partners to undertake Conservation Area Appraisal and Management Plan for the High Street Conservation Area in the centre of Doncaster.

The historic core of Doncaster includes three conservation areas, (A,B, and C on the plan opposite). This report provides detailed appraisal and guidelines for the future of the High Street. (Area C on the plan). The work was carried out from November 2006 to March 2007 in parallel with an Appraisal of the Market Place (Area B).

The elements that make up the report are a policy review, historical research, a photographic street by street survey, public consultation where the two areas (B and C) were considered together, the definition of the special interest, review of conservation area boundaries and the formulation of guidelines for the future protection of the special character of the area.

This report is intended to be adopted and published by Doncaster Council, and incorporated within a Supplementary Planning Document.



Introduction

1.2 Scope and Nature of Appraisal

High Street

The High Street Conservation Area was designated in May 1977, forming part of a network that includes a number of historic areas to the centre of Doncaster. It covers an area of 9.5 hectares / 23.5 acres and encapsulates a strip ranging from between 50 to 150 metres wide either side of the High Street; along St Sepulchre Gate, Printing Office Street and Wood Street to the south, and to the backs of the properties fronting onto Hall Gate to the north, continuing along to take in half of the urban block between the High Street and Market Place and the area between Baxter Gate and Church Way.

The High Street is one of Doncaster's most prestigious thoroughfares, following the route of the old Great North Road and featuring important buildings including the Grade I Listed Mansion House (opened 1749), together with numerous high quality 18th and 19th century buildings and early 20th century banks. Businesses along the High Street are a mix of principally financial and professional services with some retail outlets. Premises are usually retail on the ground floors with office accommodation above.

Adjoining streets are mainly medieval in origin, some indicating the line of Doncaster's historic defensive town ditch. The townscape here varies between streets where Georgian and early Victorian interventions remain largely intact, such as Priory Place, to those with a greater degree of modern replacement buildings. Businesses here are characterised by smaller, more specialist retailers.

The character of the conservation area as a whole is compact and of a human scale, with buildings generally not exceeding 4 storeys. Buildings mostly line the streets in unbroken terraces, although there are some surviving yards (once very much a feature of the town) accessed via openings to the front facades. Materials vary, but are generally of stone, brick, terracotta or painted render, with slate roofs. The High Street, St Sepulchre Gate, French Gate and Baxter Gate are pedestrianised; traffic has access to all other areas.

Planning Policy Framework

Key Planning Policy

2

Under the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990, Local Authorities are required to formulate and publish proposals for the preservation and enhancement of Conservation Areas. Government guidance contained in Planning Policy Statement 1: “Delivering Sustainable Development” and Planning Policy Guidance Note 15: “Planning and the Historic Environment” emphasises the need for the character and local distinctiveness of an area to be analysed and clearly defined in a written appraisal.

Key Planning Policy

1. PPS 1 - Delivering Sustainable Development
2. PPG 15 - Planning and the Historic Environment
3. Doncaster Unitary Development Plan (UDP) 1998
4. Doncaster Local Development Framework (LDF)
5. The Doncaster Renaissance Town Charter 2002
6. The Doncaster Renaissance Masterplan 2003

PPS1 - Delivering Sustainable Development

Planning Policy Statements (PPS) set out the Government’s national policies on different aspects of land use planning in England. PPS1 sets out the overarching planning policies on the delivery of sustainable development through the planning system.

Planning should facilitate and promote sustainable and inclusive patterns of urban and rural development by:

- Making suitable land available for development in line with economic, social and environmental objectives to improve people’s quality of life;
- Contributing to sustainable economic development;
- Protecting and enhancing the natural and historic environment, the quality and character of the countryside, and existing communities;
- Ensuring high quality development through good and inclusive design, the efficient use of resources and;
- Ensuring that development supports existing communities and contributes to the creation of safe, sustainable, liveable and mixed communities with good access to jobs and key services for all members of the community.

Planning Policy Framework

Key Planning Policy

Protection and Enhancement of the Environment

The Government is committed to protecting and enhancing the quality of the natural and historic environment, in both rural and urban areas. Planning policies should seek to protect and enhance the quality, character and amenity value of the countryside and urban areas as a whole. A high level of protection should be given to most valued townscapes and landscapes, wildlife habitats and natural resources.

PPG 15 - Planning and the Historic Environment

PPG 15 lays out the government policies for the identification and protection of historic buildings, conservation areas, and other elements of the historic environment. It explains the role played by the planning system in their protection and complements guidance on archaeology and planning given in PPG 16.

Conservation area designation is the main instrument available to give effect to conservation policies for a particular neighbourhood or area. Designation introduces a general control over the demolition of unlisted buildings and provides the basis for policies designed to preserve or enhance all the aspects of character or appearance that define an area's special interest

Doncaster Unitary Development Plan (UDP)1998

The Doncaster UDP is the Borough's statutory land use plan. It contains both the strategic policies and local planning policies necessary to guide and co-ordinate development up to the year 2001.

The policies contained within the UDP provide guidance on factors which the Borough Council will assess in determining planning applications affecting the built heritage and set out the positive measures for enhancement. The emphasis of UDP conservation policies is on control rather than on prevention, to allow each area to remain active and prosperous to encourage preservation and enhancement of features which contribute to the area's character and appearance and ensures that any new development accords with its special architectural and visual qualities.

Planning Policy Framework

Key Planning Policy

Doncaster Local Development Framework (LDF)

As part of the new planning system in England, local authorities have to prepare a 'local development framework'. The new system will replace the existing development plan, the Doncaster Unitary Development Plan. The new LDF will provide the basis for determining planning applications and future development in the borough.

Once produced and adopted, the Doncaster LDF will replace the Unitary Development Plan. Unlike the UDP the LDF will not be a single document but will consist of several smaller documents, which will allow quicker revision and alterations. It will comprise of Development Plan Documents (DPDs) - topic based documents, Supplementary Planning Documents (SPDs) - non-statutory documents, and a Proposals Map, illustrating the spatial extent of policies to accompany the DPDs. The Core Strategy DPD will set out the vision, objectives and a monitoring and implementation framework. The Built and Natural Environment DPD will identify policies required to protect or enhance areas important for the Built Environment, and the areas to which they apply. It will identify sites important for nature conservation and policies to protect and enhance them, and will also identify site-specific requirements for community needs and the reuse of surplus land currently used for community purposes.

The Doncaster Renaissance Town Charter 2002

Doncaster has been chosen to be part of the 'Yorkshire Forward' Renaissance Towns Initiative. This is the first of its kind in the UK and in direct response to the government's White Paper 'Our Towns and Cities: The Future Delivering an Urban Renaissance'. What this means is that between December 2001 to June 2002, the Council has been working in partnership with business, the community and international urban regeneration experts to create a 25 year vision of how Doncaster town centre can be transformed into a place of real quality and vitality.

The Charter sets out the main principles for the future development of Doncaster town centre and has been produced by the Renaissance Town Team, made up of representatives of the Council, the community, service providers and local business. The Town Team wants the Charter to influence the thinking of all who are involved in the development of the town centre. More importantly, the Town Team want comments on the Charter so that the vision can evolve and be responsive to change.

Planning Policy Framework

Key Planning Policy

The Doncaster Renaissance Masterplan 2003

The Masterplan has been prepared drawing on the vision set out in the Doncaster Renaissance Town Charter 2002. The Masterplan has been prepared to progress the public aspiration of the Charter and emerges from a series of consultations with relevant stakeholders and interests. The Masterplan is not definitive. It is positioned between the aspirations of the Charter and the finer detail of Supplementary Planning Guidance.

The Masterplan will carry considerable weight in influencing development and design decisions particularly if it has the support of local people and the stakeholders. The Council wishes to consider adopting the Masterplan as a framework to influence development, to set out an aspiration for a better town centre.



Definition of Special Interest

3

Definition of Special Interest

The significance of the High Street Conservation Area lies in its Roman origins. The Great North Road forms the spine of the area. This was the Roman north/south route passing by the fort of Danum. The street was enclosed within the town gates in the medieval period. French Gate and Hall Gate mark the east and west extensions to the High Street. The medieval streets that cross the High Street and the pattern of the burgage plots still survive remarkably intact. Printing Office Street marks the southern medieval boundary.

The high quality of the commercial buildings in the Area reflects the prosperity and the fashionable character of the town from the 18th to 20th centuries. Civic pride is expressed in the magnificent Mansion House, one of only three examples in the country.

The area was enhanced by some major interventions. Priory Place was cut through and forms a white-stuccoed Regency set piece. Municipal road widening schemes in the early 20th centuries resulted in the development of fine new shops, banks and offices reflecting a wide variety of architectural character within the scale and pattern of the town.

The character of the Area has been weakened by Church Way that severs the backs of French Gate, and Trafford Way that cuts off the pedestrian approach from the station and the south. The public realm is in need of improvement with areas of excess signage and street 'clutter'.

The High Street Conservation Area has also suffered both from later 20th century buildings which are intrusive and are alien to the pattern of the town plot width, height and materials. The elevations of many buildings are marred by signage and unsympathetic alterations.

Special Interest and Pressure for Change

The definition of special interest has been arrived at through an understanding of the wider area and a detailed appraisal of the High Street Area character (see chapter 4). The historical significance and urban townscape quality has been studied and the assessment of the character has been tested with the council officers, Design Panel, including Civic Trust, and the public. The appreciation of the urban quality and the concerns over the condition of the area has been expressed by the local community at the consultation events, exhibitions and questionnaires (see chapter 5).

Regeneration is anticipated along Church Way, around the station to the south and Waterdale to the east. The extensions to the conservation area boundaries were supported as a means to safeguard spaces and buildings at the perimeter of the Area; within the Area incremental change is anticipated on Hall Gate where proposals are being considered for individual and vacant plots.



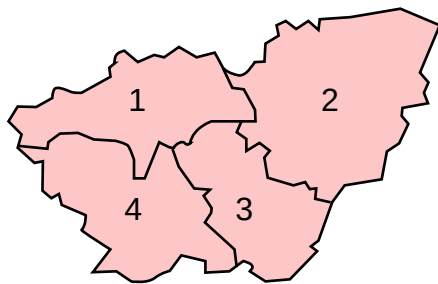
Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting

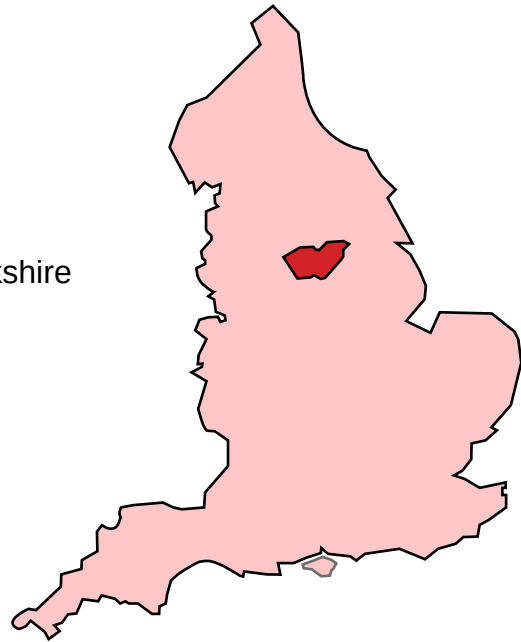
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4.1.1 Location and Context

Doncaster is situated in South Yorkshire, a metropolitan county located in the Yorkshire and the Humber region of England. The county borders Derbyshire, West Yorkshire, North Yorkshire, the East Riding of Yorkshire, Lincolnshire and Nottinghamshire. It was created in 1974 by the Local Government Act 1972 and in 2001 covered an area of 155,205 hectares.



South Yorkshire



It is divided into four local government districts;

1. The Metropolitan Borough of Barnsley
2. The Metropolitan Borough of Doncaster
3. The Metropolitan Borough of Rotherham
4. The City of Sheffield

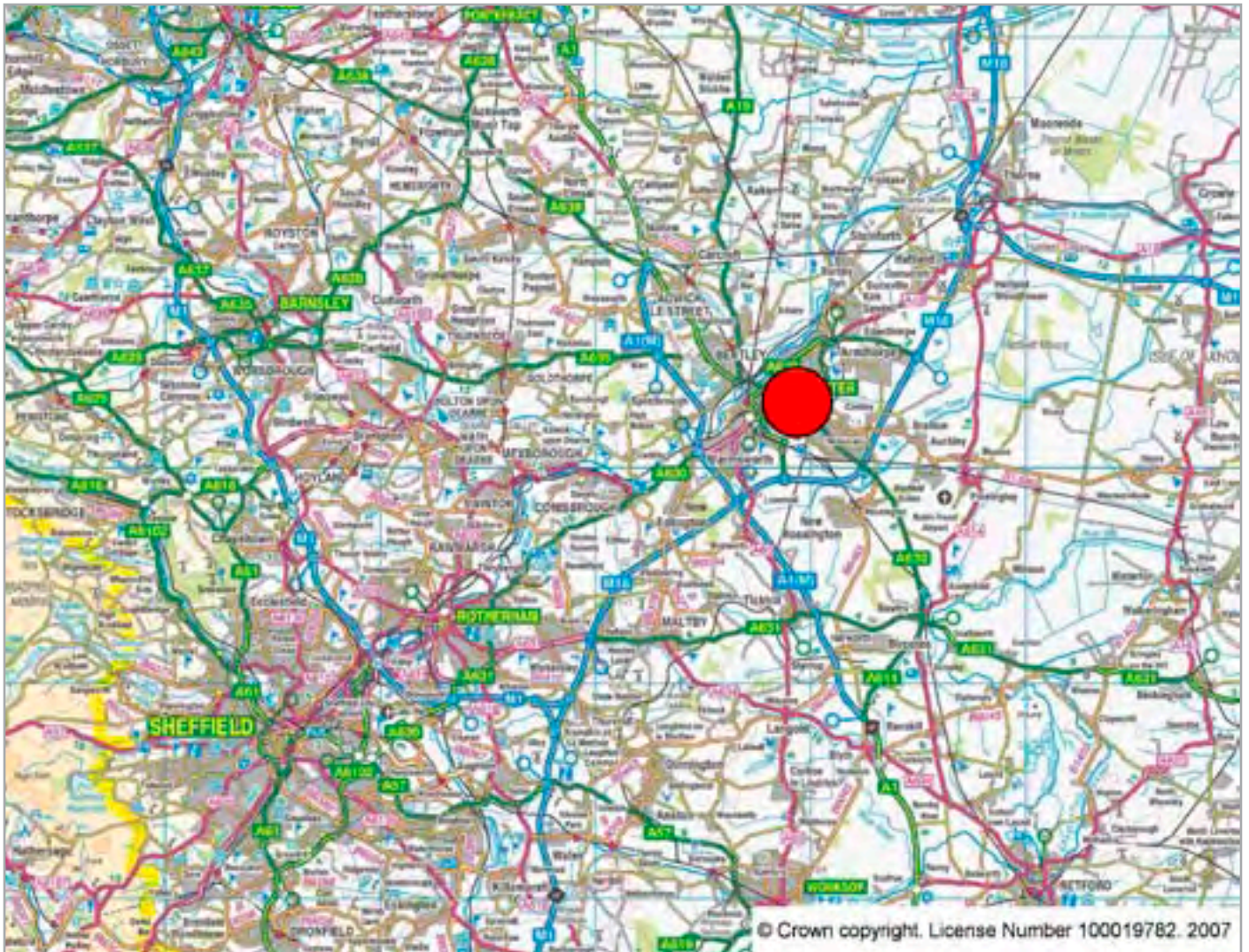
The principal settlements of South Yorkshire are:

- Sheffield, an industrial city known for steel and cutlery - England's fourth city and the only one in South Yorkshire;
- Rotherham, an industrial town bordering Sheffield on the River Don;
- Doncaster, an old Roman town and market town on the River Don, also known for railways and horse racing;
- Barnsley, a market town on the River Dearne.

The 2001 census recorded the Doncaster Urban Area with a population of 127,851, of which 67,977 are located in the central area.

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting



Doncaster and environs

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting

The High Street Conservation Area occupies the major part of Doncaster town centre. The High Street itself follows the line of the old Great North Road, being the major route into town. This, together with River Don, contributed to establishing the market as the principle focus of activity within the town and the reason for its fortunes during the early part of its history. Doncaster's location on the main north / south route and regular race meetings also made it a popular stop off for travellers. The conservation area retains much of its historic character, featuring buildings from the 16th, 18th and 19th centuries, as well as some good quality 20th century examples.



The High Street Conservation Area

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting

4.1.2 General Character and Plan Form

Located in Doncaster town centre, the High Street Conservation Area is distinctly urban in character, with the vast majority of premises occupied by retail units, financial services, offices, public houses and hotels. Very little residential accommodation exists within the town centre.

The High Street is mostly dedicated to financial services, although there are some retail outlets to be found. The principal retail areas are French Gate (a large shopping centre), St Sepulchre Gate and Baxter Gate, the latter to a lesser degree although it is still populated by some well-known national retailers. Buildings to these areas are mostly of 3 storeys interspersed with some 2 storey examples. Some 4 storey buildings exist, centred around the High Street / Hall Gate junction (1 to 5 Silver Street & the Danum Hotel).

Secondary retail areas include Scot Lane, Silver Street, Hall Gate, Wood Street and Printing Office Street. Buildings here feature more modern interventions, such as the 6 storey block at the junction of Waterdale and Hall Gate. Most, however, are of 3 storeys, with some of 2.

Buildings are divided into urban blocks with more or less continuous frontages; the centres of these urban blocks tend to open out into yards invariably used for the servicing of the commercial activities, such as for deliveries or vehicle parking. The overall plan form is therefore quite dense as would be expected of a town centre where space is at a premium, ranging from its most close-knit in the most populated areas such as High Street, before fragmenting and becoming more dispersed along outer routes such as Wood Street.

The street pattern and plan form remain largely unaltered since medieval times; Hall Gate, High Street and French Gate all make up the old Great North Road. Silver Street, Cleveland Street and Printing Office Street (sometimes referred to as the 'Bar Dike' streets) follow the line of the medieval defensive town ditch (Bar Dike) over which St Sepulchre Gate was a crossing point. Scot Lane and Baxter Gate connect the High Street to Market Place.

Linear development along the main routes took the form of medieval burgage plots, the pattern of which can still be recognised today. Building development was situated to the front of the plot adjacent to the street, with the resultant strip of land behind ploughed and farmed; back-to-back plots resulted in the 'open' centres to the urban blocks that remain to this day.

Later streets followed during Georgian and Victorian times; Waterdale & Wood Street were formerly rural tracks that were formalised, whilst Priory Place was created as a new link between High Street and Printing Office Street in 1830. Priory Walk, which runs parallel to Priory Place, is a modern intervention.

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting



View of High Street showing continuous street frontage



Plan showing open spaces to centres of urban blocks



Wood Street elevation showing fragmentation of street frontage and gaps between buildings



Rear yard to centre of urban block



Priory Walk

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting

4.1.3 Landscape Setting

Topography

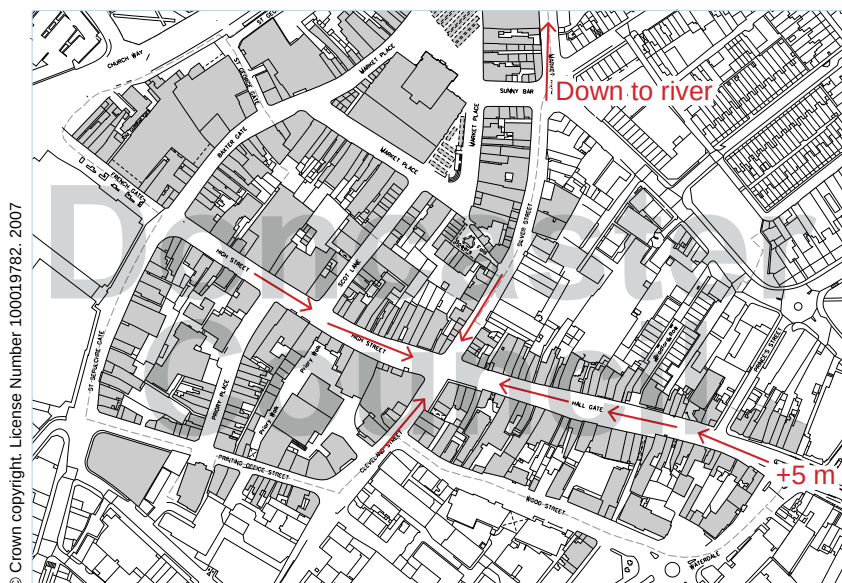
The area around the High Street is generally flat, with a gentle slope down towards the River Don, which is most pronounced around Cleveland Street. There is a low spot centred on the junction of High Street, Hall Gate and Silver Street from which there is a 5 metre incline up to the top of Hall Gate.

The wider landscape is low-lying, principally agricultural, and consists of gently undulating and rolling countryside with isolated settlements and pockets of woodland, crisscrossed by waterways and hedges together with some industrial sites. Although picturesque, there are few defining features or characteristics

The low lying nature of the topography continues into the town centre, with the result that there are few vantage points from which to gain a sense of the wider landscape and no views of the surrounding countryside from within the conservation area itself.

The urban spread of development around the town centre has all but removed any links with the surrounding countryside in the immediate vicinity of the conservation area, but open green space and agricultural land can be found relatively close by, particularly to the north of the Market Place on the far side of the river. The closest open green spaces are the large playing fields to the east that link through with the racecourse and form a 'green corridor' leading out into open countryside.

To the north of Hall Gate there is a marked change in the pattern of buildings. This denotes the expansion of housing onto adjacent rural land, outside of the old town areas, in the last two decades of the nineteenth century. Prior to this the town remained largely within its medieval boundaries; thoroughfares such as Wood Street and Waterdale existed as pre-urban tracks, undeveloped until the late eighteenth century. There is a noticeable difference between the pattern of building to the centre of the town, following the original medieval development structure, and the orderly lines of artisan's cottages to the north and south.



Plan showing slope of topography within the conservation area

Assessing Special Interest

4.1 Location and Setting

4.1.4 Geology

The South Yorkshire area is underlain by rocks of Carboniferous age which are tilted gently to the south-east so that the oldest part of the succession occurs in the west. The moors to the west of Sheffield are formed in the shales and hard coarse-grained sandstone beds of the Millstone Grit. These rocks give way to the shale, mudstone and sandstones of the overlying Coal Measures which underlie Sheffield and Rotherham. The Coal Measures are in turn overlain by the Permian Magnesian Limestone which occurs as a narrow north-south ridge from north-east of Worksop to just east of Doncaster. To the west, the low-lying moors at Hatfield and Thorne and the catchment of the River Don to the north of Doncaster are founded on the Triassic Mercia Mudstones.

The youngest geological material is that left by the melting of ice over 10,000 years ago during the closing stages of the last Ice Age of the Quaternary. This material, called till (or boulder clay), is still soft and consists of sticky clay containing boulders and pebbles .

The geology of the South Yorkshire area has been paramount in the industrial development of the area. Coal was mined in quantity in South Yorkshire from the medieval period onwards and was one of the major sources of power behind the global industrial revolution of the 18th and 19th centuries, and the early decades of the 20th centuries. Coal was mined extensively around Barnsley, Rotherham and Doncaster. The industry steadily declined during the second half of the 20th century and there are now only a few deep mines in production in the Doncaster and Maltby area.



Town centre conservation areas; Market Place in red, High Street in blue

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

4.2.1 The Origins and Historic Development of the Area

There are a number of key periods in the development of Doncaster:

- Roman
- Medieval
- 18th century
- 19th century
- 20th century

The Romano-British Period (AD 71 to approximately AD 450) and Anglo-Saxon Period (approximately AD 450 to 1066)

The establishment of the first Roman Fort at Doncaster probably dates from AD 71. The principal Roman route to York and the north was initially Ermine Street, running northwards from Lincoln and crossing the Humber by ferry crossing to Brough. To avoid the ferry an alternative route was created via Doncaster, perpetuated by the main medieval thoroughfare and extant today as Hall Gate, High Street and French Gate, crossing the River Cheswold¹ at the northernmost end of the latter. A fort was established to the north-east of the road, south of the River Cheswold, covering around 3.7 hectares. It was rebuilt in around AD 87 before being abandoned in AD 120 following the construction of Hadrian's Wall.

A civil settlement developed adjacent to the fort garrison not long after its establishment, partly due to the presence of a ready-made market for retail and other services. This is possibly the origin of the present-day market. The main part of the settlement lay to the south and south west of the fort, on modern French Gate and High Street, with ditched defences running parallel to and south west of French Gate.

The fort was rebuilt around AD 158 as a result of unrest amongst British tribes in the area. The defences consisted of a packed sand and gravel rampart with a stone wall inserted around AD 300². Several phases of buildings have been identified within the fort area, the latest dating from the late 4th century. Most buildings within the fort were initially of timber, although there is some evidence of stone buildings.

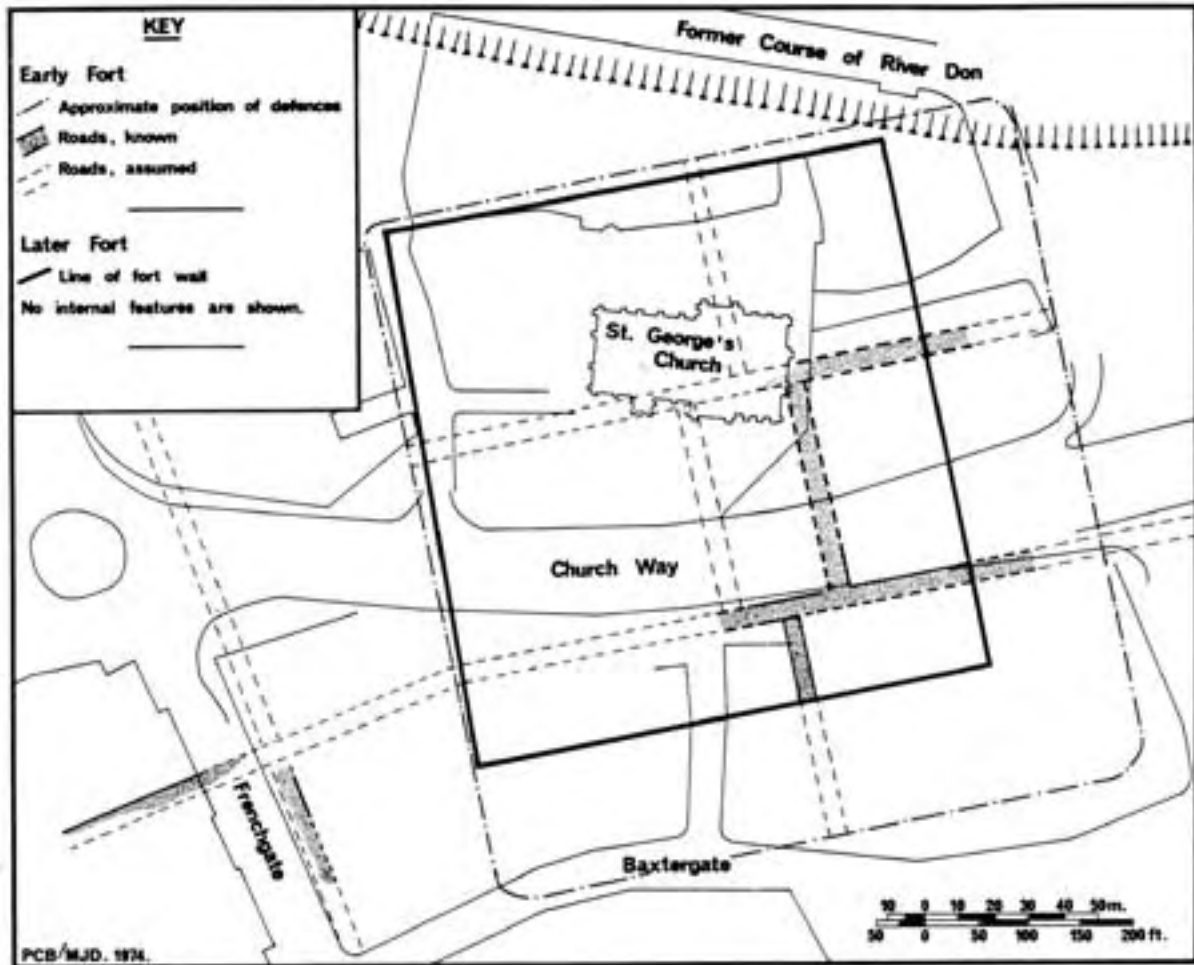
Following the breakdown of Roman rule in the early 5th century the Saxons established a settlement with a defensive ditch concentric with the Roman fort. This could have been purely military in character or contained some civil and/or administrative element; its specific nature is unknown. By the time of the Norman Conquest of 1066 Doncaster had probably developed the nucleus of a town.

The Roman and Saxon periods have left few relics, although a Roman altar was found in St Sepulchre Gate in 1781, and some fragments of Saxon pottery have been found.

¹ The river assumed this name in medieval times, but was probably the main channel of the River Don in Roman times.
² A section of this wall has been preserved north of Church Street.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology



Roman fort superimposed on 20th century Doncaster (source: *The Doncaster region in Roman Times*, John Barwick, Paul Buckland & Malcolm Dolby. Doncaster Museum Publication No.45. Doncaster Museums & Arts Service, 1975



Map of the Roman Ermine Street showing the alternative route via Doncaster in blue



Pre-Conquest Doncaster (source: *The Archaeology of Doncaster, 2. The Medieval and Later Town* by Paul Buckland, John Magilton & C Hayfield. Part (i) BAR British Series 202(i), 1989)

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

The Medieval Period (AD 1066 - 1540)

Doncaster has no separate entry in the Domesday Book of 1086, being divided into neighbouring rural manors. Most is probably included within Hexthorpe, which contained a church, priest and two mills and was priced at a substantial sum for the time; £18 in 1066 and £12 in 1086. Following the Norman Conquest in 1066 an earthwork castle was established within the north-east corner of earlier fortifications, now located under the east end of St George's Minster. This had a relatively short life span, parts of its defensive ditch having been filled in by 1200, although its presence in the late 11th-12th centuries had a lasting influence on the plan of the medieval and later town.

Growth was also stimulated around 1066 by the plantation of a group of French settlers west of the castle and immediately south of the river crossing, giving rise to the street name of French Gate. The suffix 'gate' is derived from the old Danish word 'gata' meaning 'street' or 'way'.

The Norman church of St Mary Magdalene was probably the original parish church of Doncaster, built in the present-day Market Place in c. 1130. Following demolition of the castle by 1200, the site was levelled in preparation for the new church of St George. When this church was later destroyed by fire in 1853, architectural fragments discovered in the ruins of included some of Norman origin, which may have come from the original castle chapel.

Doncaster matured into a busy town, Richard I granting it national recognition with a Royal Charter in 1193. The town suffered a disastrous fire in 1204 but was rebuilt.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

Early medieval Doncaster showing the site of the castle (source: *The Doncaster District: An Archaeological Survey*, J.R.Magilton, Doncaster Museums & Arts Service, 1977)



Later medieval Doncaster showing the urban development (source: *The Archaeology of Doncaster, 2. The Medieval and Later Town* by Paul Buckland, John Magilton & C Hayfield. Part (i) BAR British Series 202(i), 1989)



Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

The Medieval Period (Continued)

Subsequent development of the town focused on a number of 'plan units'. Some of these display evidence of town planning, whilst others appear to have developed organically in a more irregular form. The irregular, unplanned layout of the burgage plots¹ in the streets running north-east to the river from St George's Minster (Low Fisher Gate and the vanished Friendly Street) is suggestive of an earlier development, perhaps associated with the development of the town as a riverside trading settlement. The area surrounding the Minster (site of the former castle) has a similar unplanned appearance, but medieval occupation here is likely to post-date the abandonment of the castle, as the area immediately in front of the defences would have been kept clear.

The French Gate / High Street / Hall Gate area has the appearance of a deliberately planned layout, with very regular burgage plots at right angles to the street. Large plots at the western end of French Gate may have set aside for the French settlers, with shorter plots to the east as a result of the castle ditch.

The large triangular Market Place was probably laid out at the same time as the defences in the late 12th century, with the market burgage plots truncating the earlier plots along High Street. The defences themselves consisted of a town ditch, running from the river at Docken Hill along the line of the modern Market Road, Silver Street, Cleveland Street and Printing Office Street, returning to the river along Factory Lane (demolished). These streets are sometimes known as the Bardike streets. Substantial stone gates gave entrance to the town, located at Hall Gate, St Mary's Bridge (adjacent to the river at the north end of French Gate), St Sepulchre Gate and Sunny Bar.

The market centred on the church of St Mary Magdalene², although the relative positions of the two suggest that the church had been there well before the market, supported by recent evidence of a substantial medieval cemetery associated with the church.

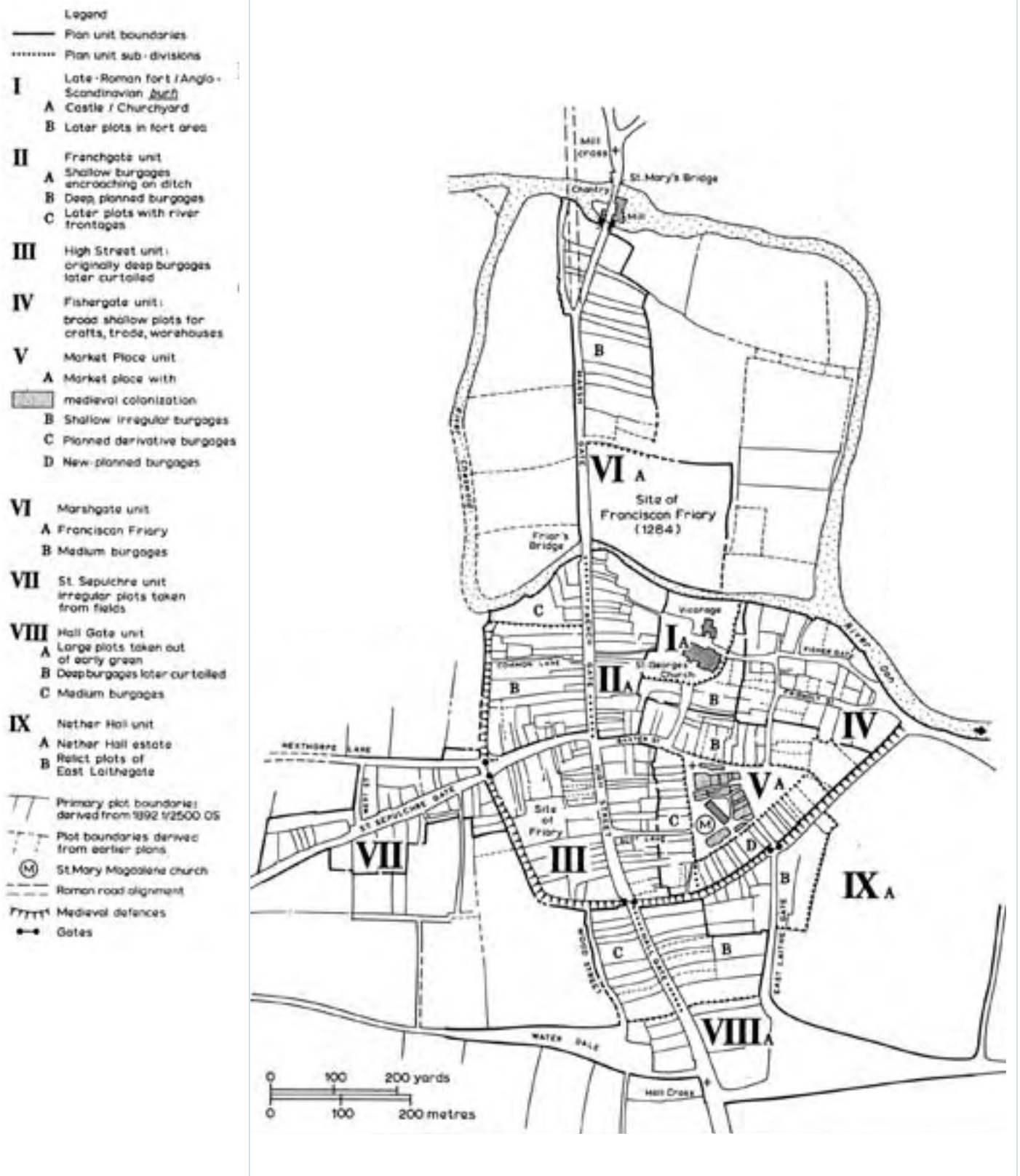
During the 14th century several friaries were established in Doncaster; in 1307 Franciscan (Grey) Friars arrived on French Gate, followed by Carmelite (White) Friars in 1346 to the south-west of High Street. The creation of the latter within the defended area suggests an absence of dense occupation in this area of the borough, and contrasts with other settlements where friaries tended to be sited in peripheral areas.

1 Burgage plots were enclosed fields established by the lord of the manor as divisions of the 'open' manorial fields. The tenants (or burgesses) paid a cash rent instead of (as previously) occupying land by virtue of having given feudal service. The basic unit of measurement was the perch, measuring 5.5 yards (5 m). Plots can be identified today because they are in multiples of perches, typically 2 by 12 (10 by 60 m), or 4 by 20.

2 Remains of the Norman church were discovered during demolition of the town hall in 1846.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology



Later medieval Doncaster showing plan units and the division into burgage plots (source: The Archaeology of Doncaster, 2. The Medieval and Later Town by Paul Buckland, John Magilton & C Hayfield. Part (i) BAR British Series 202(i), 1989)

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

The Post-Medieval Period; 16th to the 18th Centuries

During the 16th and 17th centuries the town of Doncaster continued to expand, despite several outbreaks of plague between 1562 and 1606, each of which struck down significant numbers of the local population.

Doncaster's location on the Great North Road and at the head of the navigation on the River Don ensured that its prosperity continued into the post-medieval period. It was a posting-station by 1569, while a regular carrying-service had been established by the 1630s. The town was an important inland port in the late 17th century, with the Doncaster Corporation collecting a toll of one groat¹ per ton on all goods carried up or down river.

The church of St Mary Magdalene, with cemetery, was acquired by the Corporation in 1556. For some years after the Corporation let out the churchyard in small enclosed plots or gardens. The church itself was not demolished but 're-edified'; the old chancel being fitted out for future use as a grammar school. By the early 17th century it was in use as a town hall.

The town's status as a regional market centre also brought prosperity to the town; during the late 17th century two weekly markets were held, together with five annual fairs, one lasting a fortnight. To ease congestion, from 1605 the Corporation defined distinct areas in which particular types of livestock could be sold, with cattle, sheep, swine and horses in separate locations. The horse fair moved to Waterdale in 1612. The corn and wool markets were amongst the most important in the country.

In addition to this, a wide range of trades were represented in Doncaster, with references to butchers, fishmongers, ropers, drapers, dyers, upholsterers, weavers, walkers, shearmen, shoemakers (or cordwainers) and tanners, amongst others. Despite this prosperity, the town remained comparatively small and within the confines of the medieval defences; the hearth tax returns of 1672 recorded 428 households.

18th Century

The trade of the town greatly benefited from the increase in coach traffic that took place in the second half of the 18th century. The town was strategically situated on the Great North Road and coaches ran frequently to many parts of the country. Better travelling facilities made it possible for larger numbers of visitors to attend the race meeting in September, which also boosted the town's trade. Innkeepers derived the greater part of their income from visitors, and there were a number of coaching inns, taverns and alehouses, particularly in the Market Place.

The Corporation set about making a number of civic improvements. The 1744 Mansion House by James Paine was built for the mayor to reside and entertain in, thereby promoting the town. This was followed in 1756 by a new Butter Cross and shambles in the Market Place by John Platt. The shambles provided accommodation for butcher's stalls.

1 A silver coin worth four pennies.

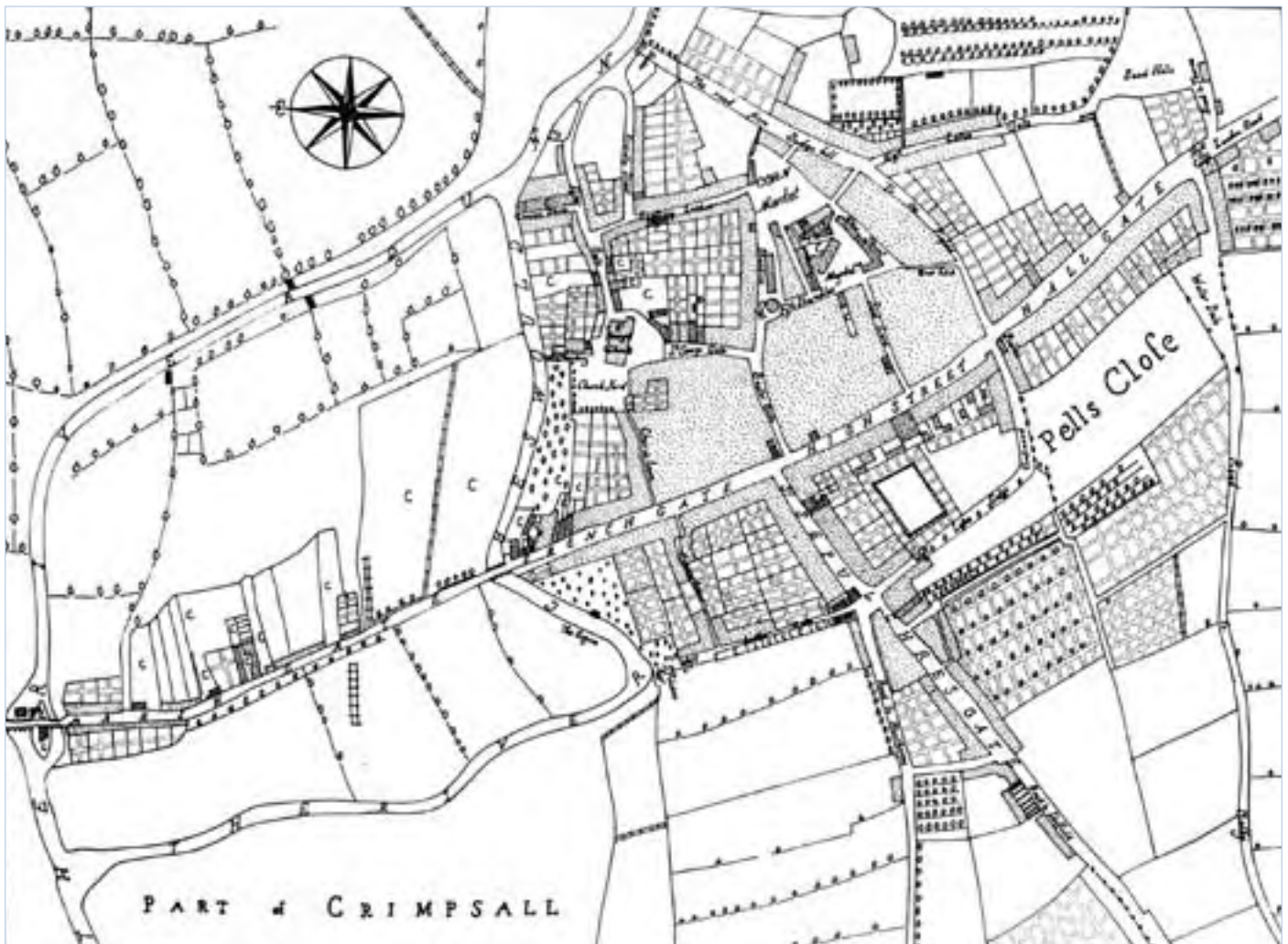
Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

In September 1776 the Theatre Royal opened in the Market Place. This coincided with the inaugural run of The St Leger, a horse race that soon became one of the country's great sporting events. Extremely fashionable, it attracted huge crowds of visitors each year.

Alongside these more high-profile works, the Corporation also adopted policies of taking down buildings which projected into the street, paving and flagging streets. In 1784 the architect William Lindley made alterations to the Town Hall in the Market Place at a cost of £340. A statue of 'Justice' representing its use as a courtroom was mounted on a triangular pediment on the front elevation.

In 1786 the first mail coach from London to the north ran via Doncaster. The town's first newspaper, 'The Yorkshire Journal' was also printed; by 1798 it had become the Doncaster Gazette.



Townsend's 1767 Doncaster Map: This shows the town still largely confined to the medieval defensive centre, with development following a linear pattern along principle routes with rural space behind. The town ditch has been filled in and the Bardike Streets established, although their modern-day names are not yet in use. Wood Street is still an rural track (source: The Archaeology of Doncaster, 2. The Medieval and Later Town by Paul Buckland, John Magilton & C Hayfield. Part (i) BAR British Series 202(i), 1989)

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

19th Century

Many of the buildings in the town centre were built around the early part of the century, mostly three storey houses with vertical sliding sash windows. With goods being imported from all quarters of the globe, the retailing trade was of growing importance, and shops were established in many featuring decorative shopfronts.

The creation of Priory Place in 1830 on the site of the former Carmelite Priory was the first major piece of town planning within the town centre for many years, creating a new terrace-lined street that linked High Street and Printing Office Street.

In 1838 the Parsonage Yard to the north of the Market Place was levelled and gravelled. Used as a wool and sheep market, this was the largest open space in the town and was the scene of many public festivities as well as for political meetings. A cattle market was opened on the site in 1869, demolishing the tithe barns that had stood there for centuries.

Following concerns that the railway had bypassed Doncaster and that market facilities were inferior to others in the region, in 1843 a covered Corn Market was erected in the north-western corner of the Market Place to designs by Mr. Butterfield, the Corporation Steward. This was the first of many civic improvements within the Market Place; a new Market Hall followed on the site of the Town Hall, the demolition of which in 1846 exposed columns and arches of the nave of St Mary Magdalene's church.

The new Market Hall opened for the sale of meat, poultry, butter and eggs in 1849, and was extended in 1866 by with a wing at the south-east end. A Corn Exchange was added in 1873; although chiefly intended for the sale of corn, the latter was designed with a view to staging concerts, festivals, exhibitions and large public meetings, and was capable of holding up to 3,000 people.

A new covered Wool Market also opened in 1868, which was further extended in 1870. The prosperity and success of the market is apparent when one considers that in 1889 6,839 cattle, oxen and other livestock and 139,972 stones of wool were brought to the market, alongside 1,000 to 1,500 sheep per week for nearly four months of the year.

1848 saw the opening of the Guildhall in French Gate and the arrival of the railway to Doncaster, providing a good connection with the industrial towns of the West Riding. Doncaster was now favourably placed for the interchange of corn, cattle and wool produced in the agricultural district to the east of the town for the supply of the large towns to the west. In 1853 the Great Northern Railway Company's Plant Works were established to the south-west of the High Street. These engineering works occupied 135 acres on an area known as The Crimpsall. By 1903 there were seven railway companies running trains into the town and a number of independent wagon building companies. The economic importance of this was huge; the Great Northern Railway Company alone employed 6,000 people out of a total population of 29,000.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

Following a fire that destroyed the original, St George's Church was rebuilt in 1857 to the design of Giles Gilbert Scott. The Doncaster General Infirmary and Dispensary was established in Wood Street in 1867, with the building later used by the Doncaster Girls' Home and School of Industry.



1852 Ordnance Survey Map: In the Market Place the Corn Market, 1st phase of the Market Hall and theatre have been built, with the shambles structures demolished. The Guildhall has been built on French Gate, and Priory Place formed between Printing Office Street and High Street, although the western terrace has yet to be built. Most streets have assumed their modern-day names, although Waterdale is called Horse Fair. What is surprising is the amount of green space that still exists, even within the bounds of the medieval settlement; extensive planted areas can be found to the centre of the urban blocks around High Street, and extensive gardens back onto the properties along Hall Gate, which appear to retain the original burgage plots. The area to the north of East Laith Gate is almost entirely rural.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

20th Century

The century began with the demolition of the theatre to be replaced by a cold store and public weighbridge for the market. Under the 1904 Doncaster Corporation Act, the Corporation obtained powers to widen several streets, including Silver Street, Cleveland Street, Scot Lane, Baxter Gate and St Sepulchre Gate. The works continued throughout the early part of the century and heralded a new age of civic improvements; other matters the Corporation sought to deal with through the act included water, gas, sanitary provisions, infectious diseases, milk provisions, common lodging houses and Hackney carriages. Many attractive and high quality buildings were built as a result of the Act.

In 1908 an extension was made to the Cattle Market towards Friendly Street and an octagonal auction ring was built. Further alterations followed in 1934. The Cattle Market was relocated in 1961 and closed in 1991.



1901-06 Ordnance Survey Map: In the Market Place the Corn Market, 2nd phase of the Market Hall, Cattle Market and Wool Market have been built, and the theatre demolished. The western terrace of PRIORITY Place has been constructed. Horse Fair has reverted to Waterdale, although access to Hall Gate is via Branson Street. Baxter Gate has been widened, the first major town improvement of this kind. The amount of open space to the centre of the urban blocks around High Street has reduced, but its total area is still relatively large. The rear gardens to the properties along Hall Gate have been redeveloped along Wood Street, and the area to the north of East Laith Gate has been laid out as terraces

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

Following World War I the Corn Exchange was hired out for political rallies; Sir Oswald Mosley and Nye Bevan were among those who took advantage of this facility. From the Second World War until the 1960s it became the Municipal Restaurant and was used as a dance hall.

A covered extension was added to the south side of the Market Hall in 1930, incorporating fish and general stalls. The extension was highly controversial, building over what had been the town centre's main open space and masking of the main elevation of the Market Hall.



1928-29 Ordnance Survey Map: Much of the town has assumed its modern-day appearance. Street widening has been carried out on Sunny Bar, Silver Street, Cleveland Street, Scot Lane and St Sepulchre Gate. Branson Street has been incorporated into Waterdale and the junction with Hall Gate widened. The era of large buildings within the town centre has begun; many with larger footprints have appeared, such as the banks along High Street, the Danum Hotel and the Cinema to the east side of Silver Street. The Cattle Market to the north of the Market Place has been extended to include an octagonal auction ring.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

20th century (continued)

Large scale redevelopment took place in Doncaster town centre during the 1960s and 1970s. The new Frenchgate Centre signalled a new era of large retailers in Doncaster town centre. Developed by the Arndale Property Trust Ltd. it was bounded by French Gate, Trafford Street, Factory Lane and St Sepulchre Gate, and involved the demolition of a large area of the historic town. Similar developments followed involving the demolition of the 1848 Guildhall. Church Way was created during the 1970s, destroying many historic properties to the west of Baxter Bate; many historic routes such as French Gate were truncated, and some such as Friendly Street were lost altogether. The road effectively divorced St George's Church from the town centre.

Following the threat of redevelopment, the Market Place was designated a conservation area in 1973. The High Street followed in 1977.

21st century

Whilst some areas of the town continue to thrive, others are suffering. The market is in need of new energy that will preserve its unique character and be a focus in the wider regeneration of Doncaster. The Doncaster Renaissance Charter (2002), acknowledged its importance, and proposed a route and activities to link the market to the waterside, more frequent, even daily use of all the market buildings and more public activity in the spaces around the market. This could both give more active use of the buildings and also reinstate the lively history of public gatherings in the Market Place.

St George's Church has been 're-branded' The Minster.

Other areas of the town centre are similarly in need of regeneration, particularly the areas around Hall Gate. It is proposed to establish a new 'cultural quarter' in Waterdale around the location of the former Girls' School, which may stimulate interest and activity.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology



2007 Ordnance Survey Map: Church Way has cut a swathe through the medieval town centre, separating St George's from the main part of town. Large scale redevelopment in the form of the Frenchgate Centre and other large stores along Baxter Gate and French Gate has disrupted the close-grain of the historic character of the town. Proposals exist for the redevelopment of the northern part of the Market Place and the area around the former Girl's School on Waterdale.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

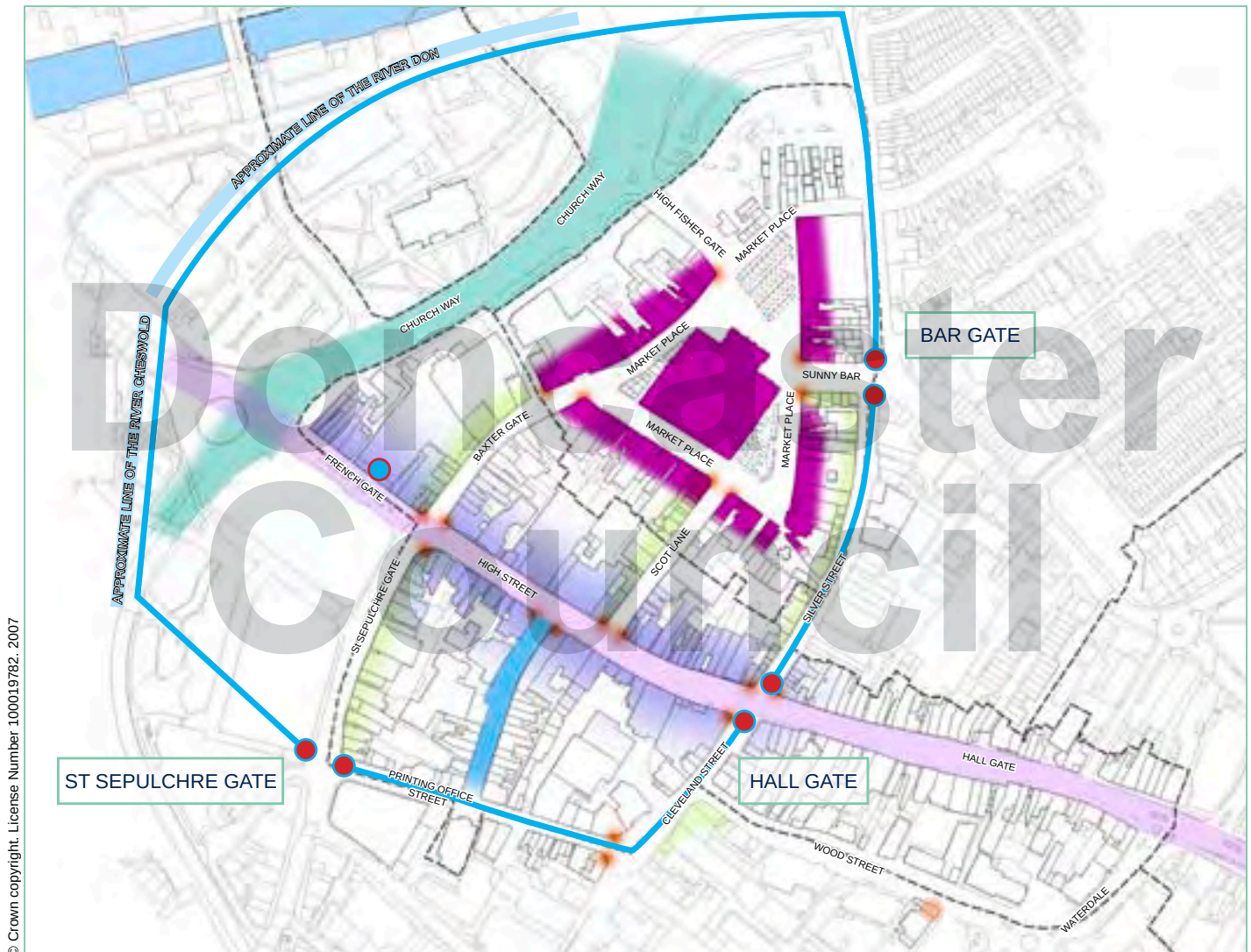
Summary

The surviving historic elements and later interventions that have determined the form of the High Street Conservation Area are as follows:

- The old Great North Road, Ermine Street and Roman Road running through the centre of the town following the line of Hall Gate, High Street and French Gate
- The town ditch that ran under the line of Market Road, Silver Street, Cleveland Street and Printing Office Street
- Roads that connect Market Place and High Street; Baxter Gate and Scot Lane
- Routes into the Market Place; High Fisher Gate, Sunny Bar and Bowers Fold
- Routes into the town centre; St Sepulchre Gate
- The surviving traces of burgage plots
- Pre-urban tracks that have been formalised into roads; Wood Street and Waterdale
- The relationship of buildings to open spaces particularly to the south and north of the Corn Exchange
- The linear pattern of buildings along routes
- The Regency creation of Priory Place
- The street-widening improvements of the early 20th century
- The creation of the Frenchgate Centre
- Cutting of Church Way in the late 20th century

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology



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-  Roman road
-  Frontages on Roman road
-  Approximate line of medieval town boundary
-  Gateways into historical town
-  Market area
-  Site of Guildhall
-  Priory Place cut through, c. 1830
-  Road widening schemes in early 20th century
-  Church Way, cut through and formed barrier
-  Rounded Corners

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

4.2.2 Archaeology, Including Scheduled Monuments

The High Street is an integral component of the historic fabric of Doncaster town. The area merits sensitive re-development in a way that protects the key archaeological remains, safeguards the historic buildings, vistas and spaces and fundamentally strengthens the townscape character. As a result of its location at core of the historic town there exists significant archaeological potential relating to its development, namely:

- The Roman fort, particularly the outer earthworks.
- The Roman road, the line of which is followed by the current High Street.
- Saxon earthworks relating to a defensive 'burh', or fortified town in the vicinity of Church Way.
- Defensive earthworks from the Norman castle in the vicinity of Church Way.
- Defensive earthworks from the French colony in French Gate.
- Medieval burgage plots.
- The medieval town ditch and defensive gates.
- The Carmelite friary around Printing Office Street.
- Trades and economic activity in the town centre.
- Evidence of older buildings within existing structures.

There are no Scheduled Ancient Monuments within the High Street Conservation Area; the closest is the remains of the Roman wall within St George's churchyard.

The historic centre of Doncaster has recently been the subject of a detailed archaeological desk-based assessment, prepared by Archaeological Services WYAS and commissioned by Doncaster Council. This will inform decisions on future archaeological investigations and proposed planning decisions in Doncaster.

The aim of the study is to identify and assess the significance of sites, buildings and finds of archaeological and historic interest within Doncaster, thereby gaining a greater understanding of the historic development of the town and the potential for the survival of sub-surface archaeological features or deposits within it.

The report is divided into two volumes;

Doncaster, South Yorkshire; Archaeological Desk-based Assessment Volume 1: Town Survey.

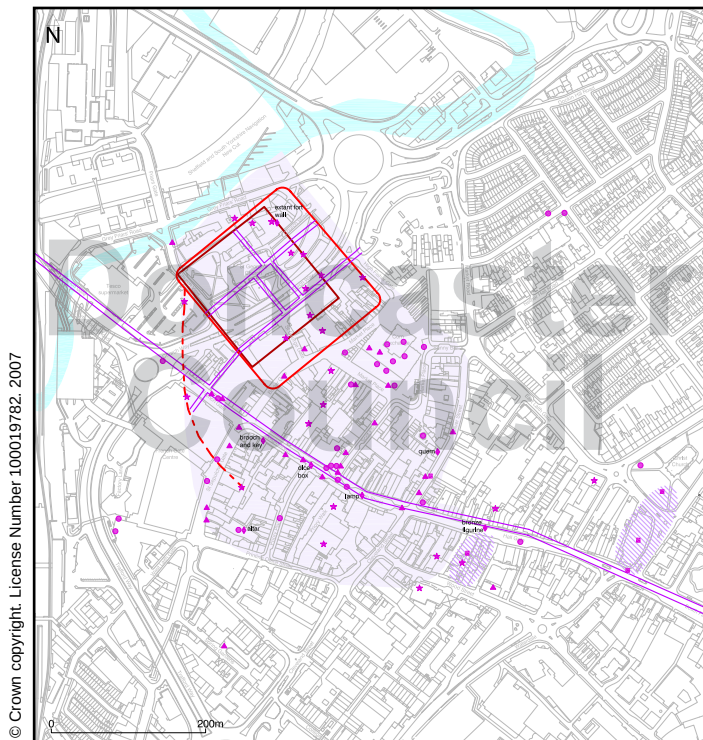
This provides a description of the methodology and sources used for the study, details of past archaeological and historical investigations, and a chronological analysis of the known archaeological record. This also includes an archaeological deposit model with a description of the predicted extent, depths and type of archaeological features or deposits that may be encountered, based on the results of previous investigations.

Doncaster, South Yorkshire; Archaeological Desk-based Assessment Volume 2: Gazetteer. This is divided into three sections; archaeological excavations, unprovenanced finds and documented historic sites, and Listed Buildings within the town centre.

These reports will need to be read in conjunction with this appraisal when considering any new development within the High Street Conservation Area.

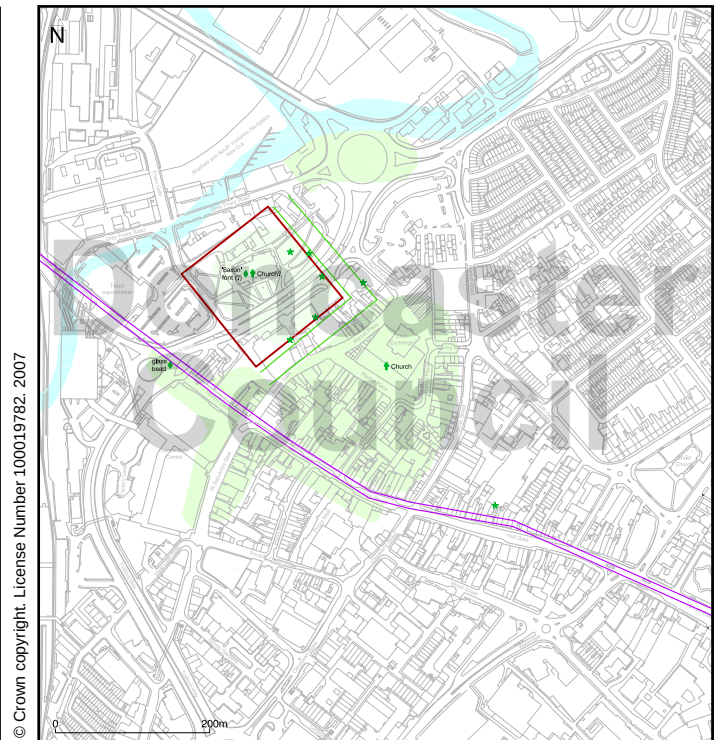
Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology



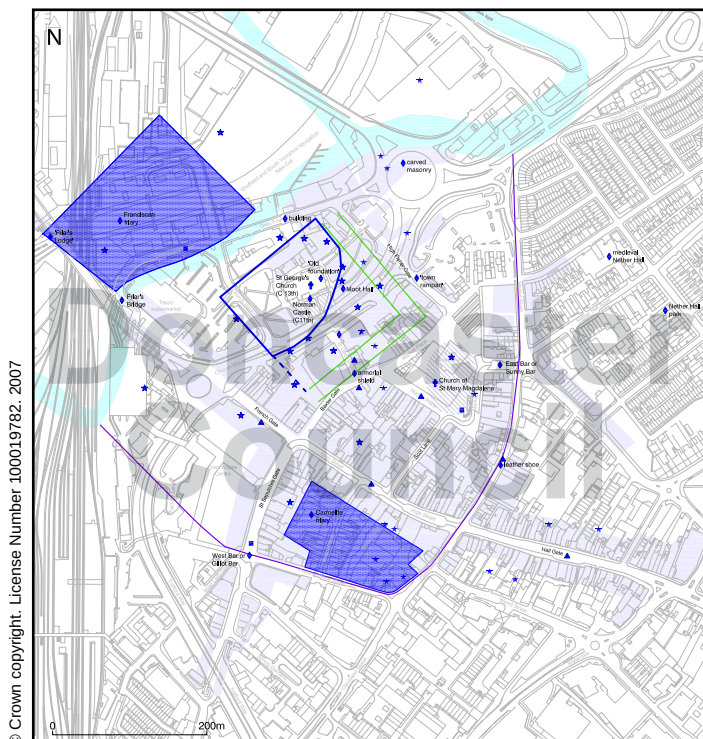
The Extent of Roman Military and Civil Occupation

- Flavian fort
- Later 2nd century fort
- Course of Roman road
- Possible area of vicus ditch
- Possible area of vicus
- Possible area of cemetery
- ★ Unprovenanced pottery find
- ★ Unprovenanced coin find
- ★ Other finds
- ★ Excavated Roman site
- ★ Burial or cremation
- Former course of the River Cheswold



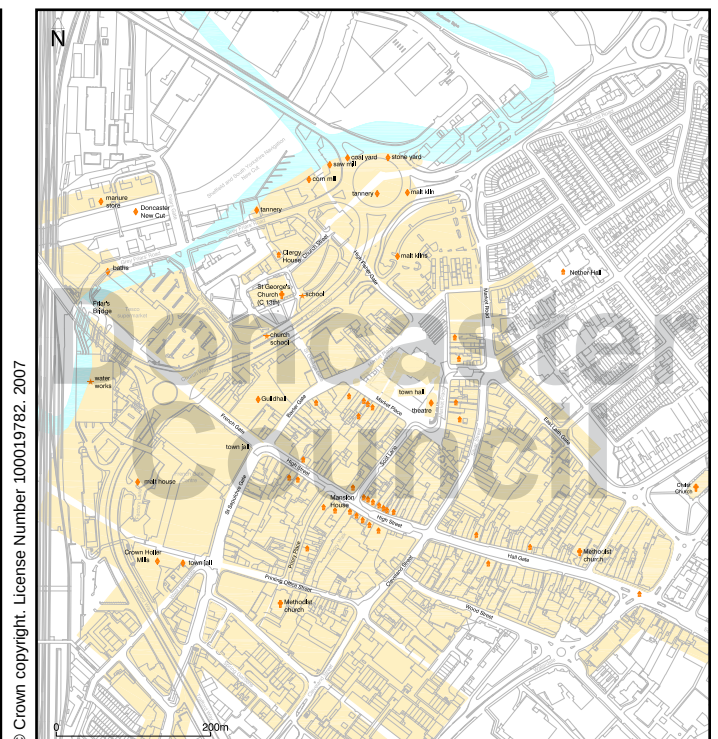
The Extent of Anglo-Saxon Occupation

- 'Burh' ditches
- Area of early Anglo-Saxon occupation?
- Later Roman fort walls
- Area of later Anglo-Saxon occupation?
- ★ Excavated Anglo-Saxon remains
- ★ Saxon church
- ★ Other finds or sites
- ★ Course of Roman road
- Former course of the River Cheswold



The Extent of Medieval Doncaster

- Norman Castle ditch
- Town ditch
- Late medieval occupation
- Graveyard
- ★ Excavated medieval site
- ★ Burial
- ★ Unprovenanced pottery find
- ★ Other finds
- ★ Church
- ★ Friary precinct
- ★ Former 'burh' ditches
- ★ Former course of the River Cheswold



Doncaster in the First Half of the 19th Century

- Area of occupation
- Excavated site
- Documented site
- ★ Extant 18th to 19th century building
- ★ Church
- Former course of the River Cheswold

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

4.2.3 The High Street Conservation Area- a Chronology Of Development

AD 43 - 450 From around 70 AD a Roman fort known as Danum was built close to a crossing point on the River Don. The Roman Great North Road dating from this time has remained the principal arterial route through the town and defines the linear character of the historic core along the High Street.

450 - 1066 Saxon rule; a fort was built on the site of the Roman Fort.

c. 1130 The Norman church of St Mary Magdalene was built in the area prior to the Market.

1190 - 1200 Following the abandonment of the Norman castle to the north west, St George's Church was built as a successor to the castle chapel.

Prior to the granting of the market charter (see below) a set of defensive earthworks were built, known as the Bardike or Town Ditch. These encircled the main business district of the town centre, with several streets following their line, known today as Printing Office Street, Cleveland Street, Silver Street and Market Road. Sunny Bar and St Sepulchre Gate intersect the streets, their names revealing that they were once entrances into defended Doncaster. As the town developed and the pressure for land increased the ditches were infilled, but their effect on the linear character of Doncaster's streets still survives today.

1193 The market was granted a charter under Richard I. In medieval times Doncaster was the most prosperous town in South Yorkshire, with Tickhill second and Sheffield third.

c. 1316 French Gate is mentioned in a deed as Francis-street. In 1360 it is known as Franksyth-gate; in 1557 premises are stated to be in French Gate, below the village of Doncaster, and 1713, French Gate.

1346 A Carmelite priory was founded, located to the rear of the current no. 44 High Street. By 1350 the priory was given 6 acres of land, and by the Dissolution (1536-40) it possessed a church, dovecote and houses within its grounds and an adjacent walled garden and orchard.

1350 Baxter Gate was known as 'vicus pistorum' - street of bakers. Baxter Gate was formed during Roman times and takes its name from 'bakster or baxter', an obsolete spelling of the word baker.

1427 Scot Lane was the street where the market toll, or scot, was collected. In 1454 it was described as 'a narrow way called Scote-Lane'.

1535 Waterdale, or Weterdale as it was sometimes known, is mentioned in a deed.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

- 1701** Silver Street was known as the way leading to Sunny Bar, in 1734 as the back lane, 1764 the road leading from Docken Hill to the Pinfold (a field on the corner of Hall Gate and Cleveland Street. It was named Silver Street in 1793 by Messrs Earnshaw and Day, apparently as a result of their fascination for coins; they originally named Factory Lane as Gold Street.
- 1750s** The trade of the town greatly benefited from the increase in coach traffic that took place in the second half of the 18th century. The town was strategically situated on the Great North Road and coaches ran frequently to many parts of the country. Better travelling facilities made it possible for larger numbers of visitors to attend the race meeting in September, which also boosted the town's trade. Innkeepers derived the greater part of their income from visitors, and the number of inns, taverns and alehouses, particularly in the Market Place still reflect this. Many of the Market Place inns were coaching inns.
- 1744** The Corporation decided that a Mansion House should be built as the mayor's residence as a place for civic entertainment. James Paine was chosen as the architect; work began in 1745 and was finally completed in 1750. The only other Mansion Houses in the country are in York and London, dating from 1725-32 and 1739-52 respectively.
- 1749** The Mansion House was opened on 15th April.
- 1767** The church, gatehouse and other major buildings of the Carmelite priory had been demolished.
- Townsend's map (see page 25) shows a road cut through Waterdale, although at that time there were no buildings on either side of the route, only closes, fields and gardens.
- 1776** The St Leger was first run, and soon became one of the north's great sporting events. The name St Leger was given to the race at a dinner held at the Red Lion Inn on the Market Place (see the plaque by the hotel entrance).
- 1789** Wood Street was opened as a thoroughfare. In the 1780s it was known as Pell's Close Lane. Extending from St Sepulchre Gate to Waterdale, Pell's Close was a field that formed the southern boundary. The name Wood Street probably derives from Richard 'Dicky' Wood, a coach and wagon proprietor who had business premises there during the early nineteenth century. He died in 1863.
- 1793** The brow of Hall Gate was lowered by the Corporation. The cross of Ote De Tilli, which had stood there for centuries, was removed.
- Public medical care began with the building of a Dispensary for the Relief of the Sick Poor in French Gate. Originally in open fields, the arrival of the railway in 1848 and a desire to provide infirmary care prompted a move to new premises in Wood Street in 1867 (see below).
- 1795** Prince's Street, on the north side of Hall Gate was laid out. The corner property on the east side, originally two houses, was designed and built by William Lindley c. 1798.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

- 1801** The architect William Lindley replaced the original pediment on top of the Mansion House with an ornamental parapet, further adding a dining room in 1806.
- 1804** The United Reform Church (now the Hall Gate Methodist Church) was built, further altered and enlarged in 1874.
- 1812** The New Bank building was built on High Street (now known as the Blue Building). The façade was remodelled in the 1920s when the blue and gold mosaic tiles were added.

The Doncaster Gazette newspaper relocated from premises in High Street to Printing Office Street, known then as Westlaith-gates. The name change followed soon after. The original Gazette premises were situated on the north side; the new entrance to Priory Place in 1830-31 cut through the centre of the printing works, the Gazette having moved out to Market Place.

Henry Preston built Beechfield Close on Chequer or Waterdale Close on the eastern side of the road. The Close totalled 5 acres, and cost £1500.

- 1814** Waterdale became a venue for horse sales and the name Horse Fair became attached to the area. When horse racing was taking place on the Town Moor, many race-goers would also visit the horse market. It also became a convenient place to hold political meetings, military parades and drills, as well as a starting point for demonstrations and processions.
- 1817** Samuel Parkinson began a confectionary business in the bow-fronted property at 50 High Street.
- 1826** Corn-mill owner Mathias Harwood built a three storey terrace to the west side of Waterdale between Young Street and Wood Street, named Harwood Terrace. In 1837 a number of professional people lived there, including a tax collector, newspaper reporter, an attorney and several gentlemen.

The Subscription Betting Rooms were built on High Street; designed by Messrs Woodhead and Hurst. Nowadays the portico is all that remains, forming the southern entrance to Priory Walk. The establishment provided entertainment for the gentry during race week, and there was a subscription fee of one guinea. When the Rooms were opened for the first time 200 members were enrolled. As well as betting facilities, food, newspapers and writing facilities were provided. During the rest of the year the building was used for public functions; Paganini gave a concert there in 1833. The Rooms were under constant police surveillance and were raided in 1871, eventually closing in 1892.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

- 1828** Reverend William Cuthbert purchased Beechfield House on Waterdale for £2,500 and opened a school. This lasted until 1841, when the property was conveyed to John William Sturgess for £2,100.
- 1830** Priory Place, its name derived from the Carmelite Priory that had existed on the site, was built when Alderman Sheardown agreed to sell land to the Doncaster Corporation to enable the building of a new road linking High Street with Printing Office Street. William Hurst laid out the road and designed the chapel to the southern end and the terraces. The latter extended only part-way along the central section of the street due to the presence of existing properties fronting onto High Street and Printing Office Street. The eastern terrace was built first followed by the western terrace, starting from the northern end.
- 1831** Cleveland Street was named on August 1 after the Duke of Cleveland. Portions of it had previously been built upon; High Street Buildings were located opposite Printing Office Street, within gardens and set back from the street. The area was redeveloped in the 1920s and new buildings erected.
- Doncaster had a population of 10,801.
- 1832** The British School was set up in Wood Street; originally intended for Quakers, the school was open to members of all denominations. The building was extended in 1876.
- 1834** The Gazette moved back to Printing Office Street, occupying premises to the southern side on the corner with Pell's Close.
- 1841** The 1841 census records twelve properties on Priory Place. There were 68 residents on Wood Street, with 14 heads-of-households.
- 1845** The Unitarians built a school fronting onto Wood Street, adjoining the rear of their chapel that faced onto Hall Gate that had been erected in 1740.
- 1848** The Great Northern Railway Company extended its route from London to York via Doncaster.
- The new Guildhall was opened in French Gate on the site of the Angel Inn. Designed by John Butterfield, it was built to replace the Town Hall in Market Place (formerly the Norman Church of St Mary Magdalene). Demolition of the original structure had revealed sections of the church walls.
- 1852** The Ordnance Survey map indicates that Printing Office Street was almost entirely built upon. Accommodation on Wood Street is focused around the western end on the north side.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

- 1853** The Great Northern Railway Company's Plant Works were established to the south-west of the High Street. These engineering works occupied 135 acres on an area known as The Crimpsall. By 1903 there were seven railway companies running trains into the town and a number of independent wagon building companies. The economic importance of this becomes apparent when one considers that the Great Northern Railway Company alone employed 6,000 people out of a total population of 29,000.
- 1857** St George's Church was rebuilt to the design of Giles Gilbert Scott following a fire that destroyed the original.
- 1863** Chequer House was erected on the corner of Waterdale and Chequer Lane. Beechfield House, the adjacent property, was acquired by Henry Foreman, who was responsible for altering and extending the house and the embellishment of the grounds. Waterdale was a desirable area in the mid nineteenth century with a number of prominent residents.
- 1867** The Doncaster General Infirmary and Dispensary was established in Wood Street. The building was later used by the Doncaster Girls' Home and School of Industry.
- 1875** The Public Health Act compelled many local authorities to attain a number of wide-ranging health standards, including a minimum width for streets.
- 1882** The name Horse Fair was dropped in favour of a return to Waterdale.
- 1885** The Yorkshire Banking Co. building (now Barclays Bank) was built on High Street.
- A new post office was opened in Priory Place, designed by Messrs Wilson & Masters, architects, of Doncaster and Sheffield. It was constructed of pressed Conisbro bricks and Huddersfield stone dressings.
- 1891** The foundation stone of the Trinity Presbyterian Church was laid in April. The building was converted into a public house, 'Camelots' in 1982.
- 1894** Clock Corner (on the corner of High Street and Baxter Gate), originally known as Oriel Chambers was built.
- 1897** The York City & County Bank (now HSBC), High Street, was built, designed by William Brierly.
- 1902** The first trams ran in Doncaster during race week following a route along High Street. Work began shortly after on extending the network along Priory Place and Printing Office Street.

Assessing Special Interest

4.2 Historic Development and Archaeology

- 1904** Under the Doncaster Corporation Act 1904, the Corporation obtained powers to widen several streets, including Scot Lane. The western side of the street was set back. Other matters the Corporation sought to deal with through the act included water, gas, sanitary provisions, infectious diseases, milk provisions, common lodging houses and Hackney carriages.
- 1908** The Danum Hotel was built, the site having been cleared to facilitate the widening of the Cleveland Street entrance onto High Street. Silver Street was widened on the west side, particularly the portion between Bowers Fold and High Street, being the narrowest part.
- 1909** Beechfield House opened as the town museum and art gallery, having been acquired by the Doncaster Corporation along with Glasgow Paddocks and Chequer House, demolished in 1910 for widening of Chequer Road and the construction of the Girl's High School.
- c. 1910 - 1930** Street widening was carried out on St Sepulchre Gate.
- 1920s** The area on Waterdale in front of Harwood Terrace was being used as a bus station and free car park, compromising its use for events. Glasgow Paddocks provided an alternative venue. The growth of the motor car made Waterdale a very busy place, as it remains today. Harwood Terrace houses were converted for commercial use, some of the lime trees that had stood since 1864 were felled, and a public toilet and shelter were constructed.
- 1924** The Wood Street Hotel was demolished for widening of the Wood Street / Cleveland Street junction. Many of the old trades in Wood Street such as printers, bottlers and cabinet-makers disappeared during the twentieth century to be replaced by shops.
- 1925** The Natwest Bank, High Street, was built, designed by William Brierly.
- 1960s** Printing of the Doncaster Gazette moved from Printing Office Street to North Bridge.
- 1966** British Home Stores began trading from new premises in the Frenchgate Centre in November. Developed by the Arndale Property Trust Ltd., the centre was bounded by French Gate, Trafford Street, Factory Lane and St Sepulchre Gate. C & A followed in 1969; their arrival signalled a new era of large retailers in Doncaster town centre.
- Early 1970s** Church Way was created.
- 1977** May; the High Street Conservation Area was established.
- 2005** Trafford Way bus station and shopping mall were linked to the Frenchgate Centre by building over Trafford Way.

Assessing Special Interest

4.3 Spatial Analysis

4.3.1 Character and Interrelationship of Spaces Within the Area

Primarily medieval in terms of the arrangement of roads, the conservation area contains no open spaces other than wide roads, the closest open space is the Market Place. Waterdale provided an open space and public meeting place during the 19th century, but lost this capacity during the early 20th century when it became the bus station; it is currently a car park. This produces a town centre that is linear in character, with buildings lining the edges of routes, the vistas of which are sometimes terminated by buildings.

The interrelationship of spaces within the town centre operates on a hierarchy, the form of the buildings and spaces indicating their importance relative to each other within the whole. Primary routes have an unbroken line of buildings tight to rear edge of pavement, with differing roof heights & designs indicating that they were built not as terraces, but individually and at different periods. The exception to this is Priory Place, the central section of which was built as continuous terraces during the 1830s, imposing some architectural order on this small part of the town centre. Some other small sections of terrace also exist; Harwood Terrace on Waterdale, and early 20th century Corporation built developments of 6 or so units along Silver Street and the south side of Printing Office Street.

The core of the town centre is characterised by relatively wide streets such as High Street, French Gate and St Sepulchre Gate, where the additional civic space is exploited to achieve visual drama through the use of individual imposing monumental buildings using giant classical orders. The massive scale, stone construction and blend of civic and corporate character engenders a sense of wealth & prosperity. This part of town has a vertical emphasis; buildings are of 3 or 4 storeys, their heights further emphasized by elements such as pilasters spanning 2 or more floors surmounted by deep overhanging cornices. When considered collectively these buildings also work as a group, further emphasizing the importance of High Street in relation to the remainder of the town.

Beyond the High Street, Hall Gate forms the continuation of the major route through the town. Maintaining approximately the same width as the High Street, this lacks any of the large commercial or civic buildings, but retains a number of imposing Georgian houses, indicators of former grandeur belying its current down-at-heel appearance. Buildings are more domestic in character, constructed of brick or stucco 2 or 3 storeys high. They tend towards a vertical emphasis individually which becomes horizontal when viewed as a continuous façade. Low eaves of varied heights and 'strips' of windows with an even size, rhythm and spacing and continuous bands of signage to the shop fronts produce a more 'human scale' in counterpoint to the High Street. This, together with the incline up Hall Gate takes the eye and attention up and out of town, making the transition from the urban to suburban and ultimately rural context.

The secondary streets such as Baxter Gate and Scot Lane leading into the High Street also serve to increase the impact of the wider, more prestigious thoroughfare, something that must have been even more apparent before they were widened during the early 20th century. These act as arteries leading into the main street, their low, narrow, linear nature offering glimpses of the major buildings and adding to the drama of the central area. This interrelationship of spaces conveys a sense of the historical development of the town centre, with roads connecting the two most important aspects of civic life; the main route and the market place. Views between the two reinforce this; the Market

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Place glimpsed from High Street down Scot Lane with the Mansion House at one end and the Market Hall at the other establishes a relationship and hierarchy between the two.

Outside of the core of the town the character the character of spaces changes again; buildings tend to be lower (2 storeys), the unbroken line of buildings fragments and development becomes less dense and more intermittent. Individual buildings are punctuated by access to car parks (often the result of later demolitions) and rear yards. This is particularly apparent along Wood Street.

Public and private space is typified by the relationship between the public street and private yards to the centre and rear of the urban blocks. The private acts as subsidiary spaces, intended as they were to service the frontage buildings. These spaces are, on the whole, hidden from view or inaccessible; yards and passageways remain in private ownership and are accessed via doors and openings in the front facades of the surrounding buildings.



The wide High Street with giant classical orders to buildings giving it a monumental, vertical emphasis



Continuous frontages of Hall Gate with common architectural features give it a horizontal emphasis



Planned architectural 'set piece' of Priory Place (above) and sparser development to Wood Street (below)



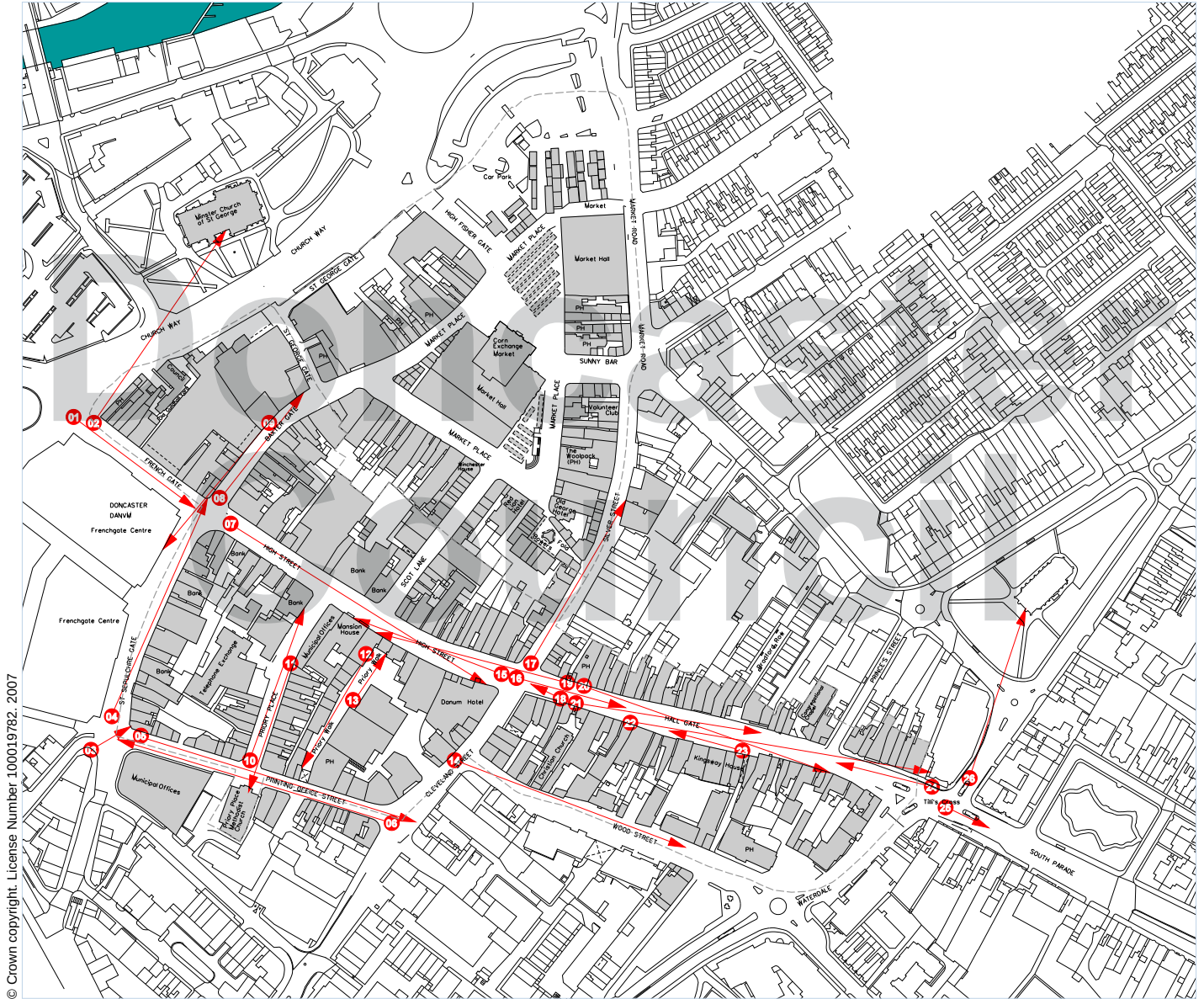
Glimpses into the High Street from adjoining routes (here viewed from Scot Lane) establishes a hierarchy and adds to the visual drama of the central area



Passageway showing the relationship between public street and private space beyond

Assessing Special Interest

4.3 Spatial Analysis



Plan showing key views and vistas within the town centre

Assessing Special Interest

4.3 Spatial Analysis

4.3.2 Key Views And Vistas

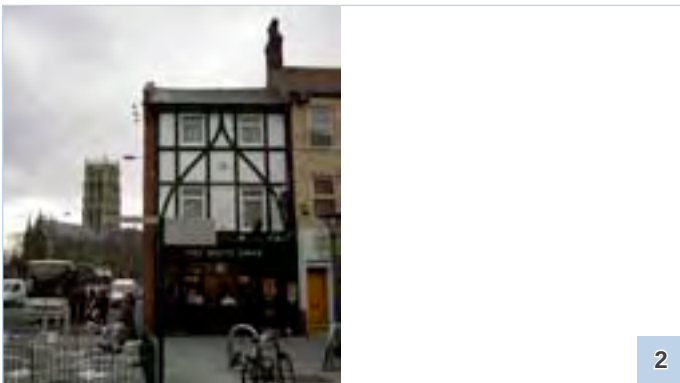
General: The varied nature of the spaces within the conservation area offer a number of differing types of view that identify:

- The change in scale from micro to macro.
- The transition from public to private space.
- The transition from enclosure to open space.
- The positioning of High Street at the heart of Doncaster town centre and its relationship to other important landmarks such as St George's Minster and Market Place.
- The hierarchy of spaces within the town centre itself, such as Priory Place in relation to High Street, and Hall Gate in relation to High Street.



The view is one of the last vestiges of the old Great North Road and establishes its primacy as a route through the town.

View 01: French Gate facing east



Ironically, this view is only possible as a result of the creation of Church Way, which truncated French Gate. It establishes St George's Minster as a presence within the town .

View 02: French Gate to St George's Church



The view asserts the importance of the former *Public Benefit Boot & Shoe Company* building as a local landmark, as well as establishing the site of the former gate in the town's defences in the foreground.

View 03: West Laith gate to corner St Sepulchre Gate / Printing Office Street

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One of the ancient thoroughfares into the town, the view focuses on the 1894 Clock Corner as an impressive local landmark.

View 04: St Sepulchre Gate facing north



Printing Office street follows the line of the original town ditch, marking the extent of the original medieval settlement.

View 05: Printing Office Street facing east



The view perpetuates the line of the town ditch and establishes its ancient relationship with St Sepulchre Gate.

View 06: Printing Office Street facing west



A view illustrating the visual drama and canyon-like qualities of the High Street and the impressive scale and ornament of the buildings.

View 07: High Street facing east

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The view establishes the narrowness of Baxter Gate relative to High Street and hints at the existence of the Market Place beyond.

View 08: Baxter Gate facing north



One of the oldest routes within the town centre, Baxter Gate has a lively mix of building styles and retailers, typified by this view.

View 09: Baxter Gate facing south



The view illustrates the planned nature of the street, with regular terraces sharing common details and a uniform roof line. The late 20th century post office extension interrupts the vista by breaking the original frontage line.

View 10: Priory Place facing north



One of the few planned views in the town centre, the chapel was built to terminate the vista along the street. It is built off-centre due to land acquisition problems.

View 11: Priory Place facing south

Assessing Special Interest

4.3 Spatial Analysis



12

View 12: Priory Walk facing south



13

View 13: Priory Walk facing north



14

View 14: Wood Street facing east



15

View 15: Junction High Street / Hall Gate facing west

Priory walk is suggestive of the linear nature of the spaces that once existed to the centre of the urban block. Historic buildings survive to the west (right) side.

The view establishes a hierarchy between High Street and the subsidiary spaces behind the main facades.

Wood Street marks the former edge between the urban and rural.

The view into the High Street establishes the Mansion House as the centre of civic life.

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The view takes the eye up and out of the town centre, suggestive of the open land beyond.

View 16: Junction High Street / Hall Gate facing east



Silver Street follows the line of the old defensive town ditch, even today suggesting a boundary with the town centre.

View 17: Silver Street facing north



Further views (together with 19 below) down into the centre of the town to the historic centre, with Mansion House as its showpiece.

View 18: Junction Silver Street / High Street from Hall Gate



View 19: High Street from Hall Gate

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4.3 Spatial Analysis



20

Views 20 to 24 illustrate the impressive Georgian development along Hall Gate, with continuous frontages and common architectural elements such as sash windows, stepping down into the town centre and appearing very much as a complete, planned gesture despite being constructed individual basis.

View 20: Hall Gate facing east (1)



21

Some late 19th / early 20th century buildings add architectural motifs such as profiled gables to the palette, but the character is still overwhelmingly Georgian.

View 21: Hall Gate facing east (2)



22

The gap site on the northern side of the road breaks the line of historic frontages and should be sympathetically redeveloped as a matter of urgency.

View 22: Hall Gate facing east (3)



23

Modern interventions such as Kingsway House (left) interrupt the line of historic buildings, but the impact is modulated by relating to original frontage widths and eaves heights.

View 23: Hall Gate facing west (1)

Assessing Special Interest

4.3 Spatial Analysis



24

The view here is spoilt by utilitarian street furniture and the multitude of different surfaces.

View 24: Hall Gate facing west (2)



25

As well as taking in the impressive facades of the properties on South Parade, the appearance of trees and vegetation suggests rural spaces beyond the town centre.

(This area is outside the conservation area)

View 25: Hall Gate to South Parade



26

The view suggests spaces beyond the town centre and establishes a relationship with the impressive Christ Church, originally built in 1829.

(This area is outside the conservation area)

View 26: Hall Gate to Christ Church